religious properties in Gujarat.

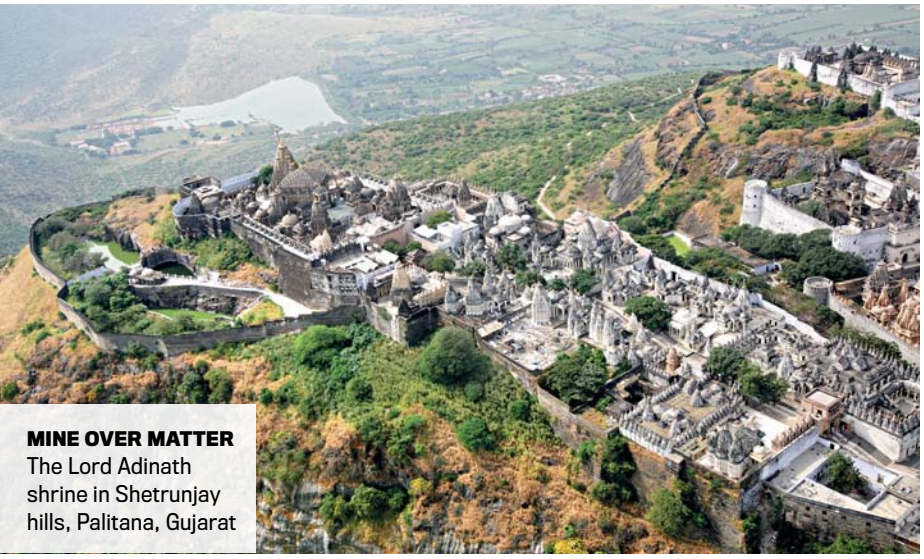
The local Bharwad and Ahir communities have also laid claim to the hill, especially over the right to celebrate Mahashivratri at a Shiva temple atop the hill and stay there overnight, which violates the Jain way of worship.

Gujarat MoS for home Harsh Sanghavi, a Jain himself, says all the issues will be resolved at the earliest. "We have formed an eight-member task force of key police and revenue officials of the region to bring a lasting solution to the issue," says the minister.

But as time passes, the sentiment is getting sharper—especially on social media—that a BJP conspiracy is afoot to convert Jainism into a *sanatan dharma*. "Politically, we can only align with the BJP, but we must not forget that in the past, Narendra Modi as chief minister had tried to merge Jainism into Hinduism. Some sadhus are still trying to do this and they are not being reined in by the government. What should we glean from this?" asks an Ahmedabad-based Jain activist. He is referring to the Freedom of Religion (Amendment) Bill passed by the Gujarat assembly in 2006, which bracketed Jains and Buddhists under Hindus. Following widespread protests, the bill was sent back to the assembly in 2007. It hasn't surfaced since. In 2014, the UPA government of Manmohan Singh gave 'minority community' status to Jains at the national level; the Rupani regime followed suit in Gujarat in 2016.

Meanwhile, Sanjay Jain, president of the Vishwa Jain Sangathan, lays out the community's demands over the issue of Parasnath Hill as an ecotourism spot. Here again, the BJP is being blamed—its government was in power in Jharkhand in 2019 when it notified the area for development as an ecotourism spot. "The government must issue a revised gazette notification, replace 'ecotourism' with 'Jain religious pilgrimage spot' so as to protect the region. We will not rest till this happens," Jain says. He points to the eight-month-long attempt for talks with Union environment and forest minister Bhupender Yadav, which, Jain claims, yielded no result till the protesters took to the roads in the new year.

However, there are others who contest the Jain claim itself. The tribals of the Giridih hills, for instance regard it as their sacred place of worship. "We have been guarding the region for generations. The sacred hill is Marang Buru, and we worship there as our customs dictate. We will not let anyone stop us," says tribal rights activist Sikander Hembrom. However, Jain claims that Marang Buru is the tribal term for Lord Parshwanath, after whom the Parasnath Hill and wildlife sanctuary are named. "There is no conflict with the tribals who are nature worshippers...these protests are pure politics. All this will settle once the government withdraws the notification," he says. Only then, it seems, will the religion of peace be at peace again. ■



SHAILESH RAVAL

MINE OVER MATTER
The Lord Adinath shrine in Shetrunjay hills, Palitana, Gujarat

By Rahul Noronha

South Chhattisgarh, often in the news for Left-wing extremism-linked violence, has been rocked by a series of communal incidents in the past three weeks. Tribal Hindus have allegedly attacked tribal Christian converts in the Narayanpur and Kondagaon districts of the state, with hundreds of tribal Christians being forced to flee their native village homes. Call it an ethnic conflict with a twist because, in many cases, members of the two sides are related to each other. What has led to a situation wherein tribal has turned against tribal? The ruling Congress blames the BJP for attempting to sow discord, even as the latter calls the attacks 'spontaneous'.

In the latest incident on January 2, a protest called by tribal Hindus after a minor altercation involving Christians—which was led by Roop Singh Salam, the BJP Narayanpur district president—turned violent. The protesters vandalised a church and attacked superintendent of police Sadanand Kumar, resulting in injuries to his head. Some other policemen were injured too. A total of 15 people have been arrested from both sides, including Salam.

The saffron party, however, has distanced itself from the attacks. "The BJP has nothing to do with the attacks. Having said that, it is true that forcible conversions have been an issue in Bastar for some time now. If you recall, the Sukma SP had in July 2021 flagged the issue of the possibility of violence owing to tensions between converted and non-converted tribals," said Prabal Pratap Judeo, BJP state secretary and son of late Dilip Singh Judeo, the BJP leader who initiated the process of 'ghar wapsi' or recon-